

A REFLECTION ON RAMADAN AND THE MIND

Ma'asalama Ya Ramadan

The Psychological and Spiritual Transformation

اللهم إني أعوذ بك من قلب لا يخشع، وعين لا يدمع، ومن دعاء لا يستجاب، ومن نفس لا تشبع

“O Allah, I seek refuge in You from a heart that is not humble, an eye that does not weep, a prayer that is not answered, and a soul that is never satisfied.”

— Qunūt, recited in the final nights of Ramadan

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I. The Discipline of Restraint

It feels like it was only yesterday that we were eagerly whispering, “Marhaban ya Ramadan” (Welcome, Ramadan). Now, with heavy hearts and tearful eyes, we find ourselves waving goodbye. How swiftly the blessed days have slipped through our fingers, yet how deeply they have rewired our minds! We will miss you, Ramadan.

Thank you, Ramadan, for being the ultimate masterclass in human psychology and resilience. Within your days and nights, we learned the true extent of our mental fortitude. Through the delayed gratification of fasting, we trained our willpower and executive functioning. We discovered that we can endure hunger and thirst for the sake of Allah, finding hidden cognitive reserves and sharp mental clarity instead of sheer exhaustion.

II. The Neuroplasticity of Devotion

You showed us the incredible neuroplasticity of our brains. Before you arrived, maybe we were too busy or lazy with the world to read the Qur'an daily. But with you, we learned that sustained focus—completing its recitation twice, thrice, or even four times—is entirely within our reach. We learned the psychological power of disrupting our routines, sacrificing sleep only to rise fresh, experiencing the profound mental clarity that comes from standing humbly before Him in the quiet of the night.

III. The Safest Space for the Heart

From you, we learned the profound art of emotional regulation and vulnerability. You taught us that the safest therapeutic space to process our anxieties and let our tears fall is in absolute privacy before Ar-Rahmān (The Most Merciful). You reminded us that our ultimate “grounding technique” is not just a physical space, but the posture of prayer while in Sujūd, naturally activating our parasympathetic nervous system and bringing profound calm. You proved to us that the ultimate cognitive and emotional healing is found within the mindful reading of the Qur'an and the active pursuit of drawing closer to Allah.

IV. A Bittersweet Departure

Ramadan, you have departed all too quickly, but you have fundamentally lowered our stress baselines and left us infinitely more peaceful than we were before. Now, our minds are filled with a bittersweet longing, and we are already counting the days until you grace us with your presence again.

We will miss the beautiful rush hurrying to the mosque for tarāwīh and tahajjud, experiencing the psychological joy of shared purpose and community. We will miss the mesmerizing tilāwah of the qurrā', whose voices guided us into a deep state of spiritual awe. We will miss the prolonged qunūt and the profound collective catharsis of the entire mosque crying in every corner when the Imam pleaded:

اللهمّ! إني أعوذ بك من قلب لا يخشع، وعين لا يدمع، ومن دعاء لا يستجاب، ومن نفس لا تشبع

“O Allah, I seek refuge in You from a heart that is not humble, an eye that does not weep, a prayer that is not answered, and a soul that is never satisfied.”

— Qunūt, recited in the closing nights of Ramadan

Sharing that raw, unrestrained emotional release alongside hundreds of others healed us in ways words cannot easily describe.

V. What the Month Leaves Behind

We will miss the irreplaceable warmth of Iftar, where breaking our fast together fostered deep social connection and belongingness with our loved ones. Most of all, we will miss the unparalleled, quiet tranquility that only your days can bring.

To put it in the terms of modern neuroscience: you were our spiritual serotonin, our divine dopamine, and the ultimate booster of every happiness hormone in our minds. You healed not just our souls, but our entire psychological well-being.

Ma'asalama ya Ramadan.

May Allah allow us to reach you once again.